

Urinary & Fungal Infections



Echinacea
(*Echinacea* spp.)

Infections signal that the body's resistance to disease has become weakened, particularly if they are long-lasting or recurrent. Minor infections affecting the kidneys and urinary system are common and, despite being hard to shake off, can be treated by boosting the body's natural defenses. Fungal infections can also be difficult to clear and may require professional treatment, although herbs such as garlic (*Allium sativum*, p. 59) and tea tree (*Melaleuca alternifolia*, p. 112) are strongly antifungal. If the infection is chronic, it is necessary to support the immune system as a whole, with herbs such as echinacea (*Echinacea* spp., p. 92).

❗ Seek immediate professional advice for:

- Infections that show no signs of improvement, or deteriorate after taking an herbal remedy
- Temperatures above 102°F (39°C)
- Pain in the kidneys
- Blood in the urine

🌿 Urinary Infections

Cystitis (an infection of the bladder and urinary tubules) can be a serious problem if it spreads to the kidneys. Mild cystitis and other urinary infections can be cured with a mixture of antiseptic herbs such as buchu and soothing herbs such as marshmallow. Taking echinacea or garlic at the same time improves the body's resistance to infection. Bilberry or cranberry, which are from the same genus, are excellent for urinary infections.

❗ **General cautions** Seek immediate professional help if cystitis is severe or recurrent, or if there is blood in the urine or pain around the kidneys or small of the back.

General Remedies

Herbs Buchu (*Barosma betulina*, p. 71), comsilk (*Zea mays*, p. 154), marshmallow (*Althaea officinalis*, p. 165)

Remedy Make an infusion with 5 g of each herb to 3 cups (750 ml) of water. Divide into 4 doses and drink throughout the day.

Option Substitute juniper (*Juniperus communis*, p. 224) or goldenrod (*Solidago virgaurea*, p. 271) for buchu.

Caution Do not take juniper or buchu during pregnancy.

Herb Bilberry (*Vaccinium myrtillus*, p. 147)

Remedy Make a decoction of the berries and drink 1½–2½ cups (450–600 ml) a day.

Tip Cranberry juice may be substituted for bilberry decoction.

Herbs Garlic (*Allium sativum*, p. 59), echinacea (*Echinacea* spp., p. 92)

Remedy Take either or both herbs in capsule or tablet form.

Note Take in addition to other remedies.

🌿 Fungal Infections

Fungal infections are common and can be hard to treat. Vaginal yeast infection is increasingly found as a side effect of conventional antibiotic treatment. Calendula is helpful for treating this troublesome condition. Candidiasis (accelerated growth of *Candida albicans*, a yeastlike organism within the gut) can cause considerable problems, but mild cases may be helped with antiseptic and antifungal herbs, such as garlic. All types of fungal infections can be helped with herbs that boost the immune system, such as echinacea, as well as by applying an external remedy to the affected area.

Diet

Diet is an important factor when treating fungal problems. Cut out or reduce intake of bread, alcohol, and other foods containing yeast or sugar.

Self-help

Candidiasis sufferers can take probiotic capsules or live yogurt to help the growth of beneficial bacteria in the intestines. For yeast infection, live yogurt can be inserted into the vagina.

❗ **General caution** Seek professional advice for candidiasis, as it is often a difficult condition to treat.

General Remedies

Herbs Echinacea (*Echinacea* spp., p. 92), thyme (*Thymus vulgaris*, p. 143)

Remedy Mix 2 parts echinacea tincture to 1 part thyme tincture and take 1 tsp twice a day with water.

Herb Garlic (*Allium sativum*, p. 59)

Remedy Take 1–2 garlic cloves a day, crushed and swallowed with water or mixed with food.

Vaginal Yeast Infection

Herb Calendula (*Calendula officinalis*, p. 73)

Remedy Make an infusion and allow to cool. Strain and use as a douche or wash.

Option Add the infusion to a bath and soak for 20 minutes.

Herb Tea tree (*Melaleuca alternifolia*, p. 112)

Remedy Use pessaries or place 1–2 drops of essential oil diluted with 3 drops of olive oil on a tampon and insert into the vagina (this may sting). Remove after 2–3 hours and only use once a day.

❗ **Caution** During pregnancy, use these pessaries and tampons only with professional advice.

Oral Thrush

Herbs Licorice (*Glycyrrhiza glabra*, p. 101), myrrh (*Commiphora molmol*, p. 85), echinacea (*Echinacea* spp., p. 92)

Remedy Mix equal parts of the tincture of each herb. Take 1 tsp as a mouthwash with water every 3–4 hours, as required.

Candidiasis

Herbs Elderflower (*Sambucus nigra*, p. 132), calendula (*Calendula officinalis*, p. 73), thyme (*Thymus vulgaris*, p. 143)

Remedy Make an infusion with 8 g of each herb to 3 cups (750 ml) water and drink 1¼–1½ cups (300–450 ml) each day.

Herb Pau d'Arco (*Tabebuia* spp., p. 139)

Remedy Make a decoction with 12 g bark to 3 cups (750 ml) of water. Divide into 3–4 doses and drink throughout the day. Alternatively, take capsules or ½ tsp of tincture with water up to 3 times a day.

Fungal Skin Infections, Including Athlete's Foot

See p. 304.